

Best Exercises for Back Arthritis: A Complete UK Physiotherapist

UK physiotherapist-approved exercises for back and spinal arthritis.

Step-by-step strengthening, mobility and aerobic exercises to reduce pain and improve function.

By **Living With Arthritis UK Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Chartered Physiotherapist** (MCSP, HCPC registered) · 2026-06-05 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk



*Person performing gentle back mobility exercises for spinal arthritis
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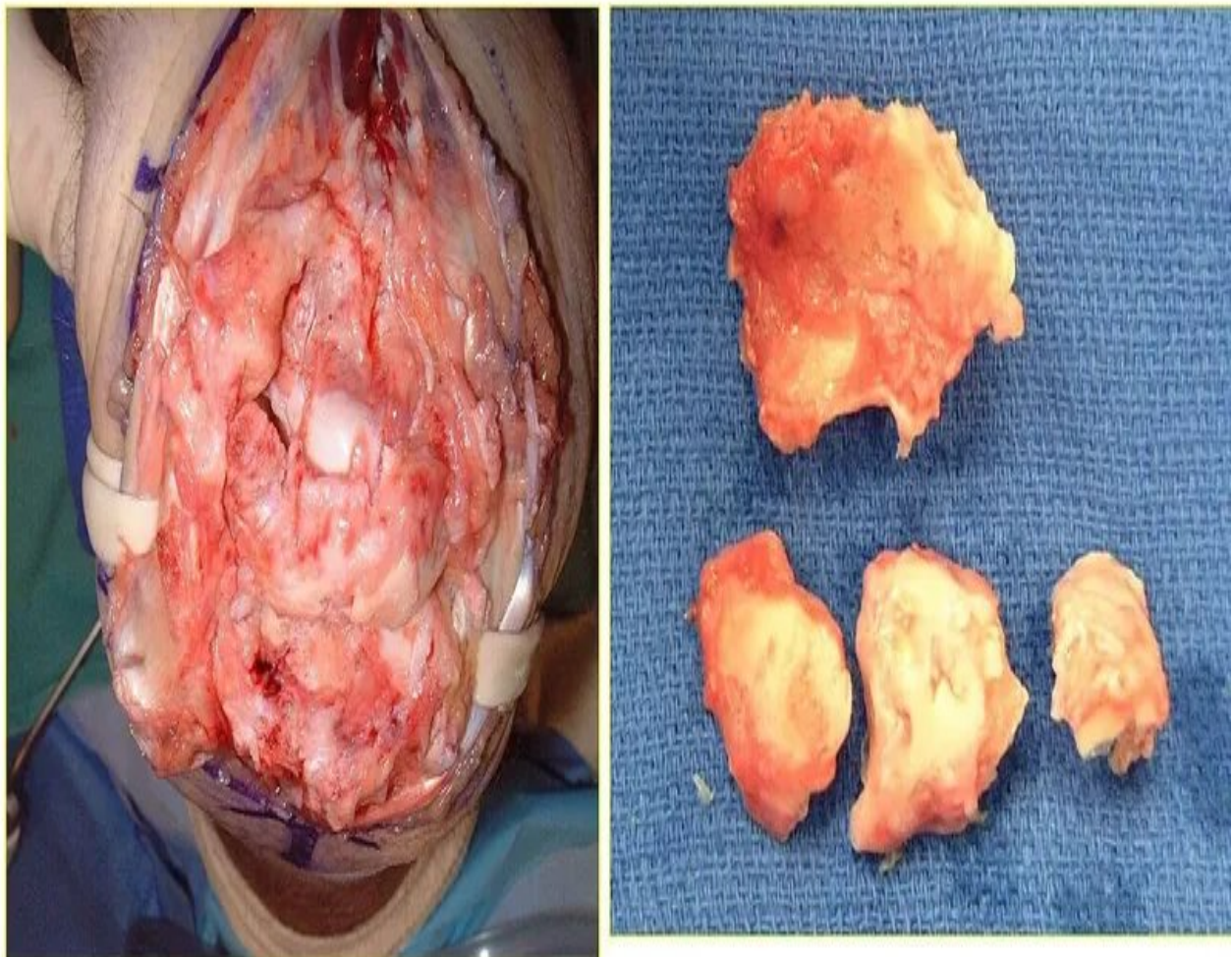
Back and spinal arthritis (including spondylosis and facet joint OA) affects a large proportion of UK adults over 50. NICE recommends exercise as a **core treatment**,

and a structured 12-week programme can reduce back pain by 25–40% — comparable to standard analgesia.

Why Exercise Is Essential for Back Arthritis

Regular movement nourishes intervertebral discs, strengthens the deep core and back extensors that stabilise the spine, improves posture, and slows progression. The most common concern — "will exercise damage my spine?" — has a clear evidence-based answer: appropriate, graded exercise does not accelerate spinal degeneration and is the most effective non-surgical treatment.

Strengthening Exercises



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1. Pelvic Tilts

Lie on your back with knees bent and feet flat. Gently flatten the lower back into the floor by tilting the pelvis. Hold 5 seconds. Repeat 10 times. 2–3 sets.

2. Bird-Dog

On hands and knees, extend opposite arm and leg slowly. Hold 5 seconds. Lower with control. 8–10 reps each side. 2 sets.

3. Glute Bridges

Lying on your back with knees bent, lift the hips towards the ceiling, squeezing the glutes. Hold 5 seconds. 10–12 reps. 2–3 sets.

4. Wall Squats (Partial)

Back against a wall, slide down to a quarter-squat. Hold 10 seconds. Build to 30 seconds. 3 sets.

Mobility Exercises

5. Cat-Cow

On hands and knees, alternate between arching and rounding the back smoothly. 10 slow cycles. Do daily.

6. Knee-to-Chest Stretch

Lying on your back, gently draw one knee to the chest. Hold 20 seconds. Swap sides. 3 each side.

7. Lower-Back Rotation

Knees bent, drop both knees gently to one side, then the other. 10 cycles. Keep shoulders down.

Aerobic Exercises



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Walking, stationary cycling and swimming (especially backstroke) are the most studied low-impact options for back arthritis. Aim for 30 minutes most days, which can be split into 3 × 10-minute sessions.

Back Exercises for Osteoarthritis

For spinal OA and spondylosis, the priority is deep-core strengthening (transverse abdominis activation, bird-dog) combined with hip-flexor mobility and low-impact aerobic work. NICE places this alongside weight management as the core treatment. See our osteoarthritis exercises guide and osteoarthritis treatment overview.

Back Exercises for Rheumatoid Arthritis

RA can affect the cervical spine in particular. During flares, restrict to gentle mobility only and avoid loaded extension. Hydrotherapy in warm water (33–35 °C) is well tolerated. Full programme: rheumatoid arthritis exercises.

Gentle Back Exercises for Severe Arthritis

Pelvic tilts, supported knee-to-chest, cat-cow and pool walking allow you to keep the spine moving without overloading it. Two short 10-minute daily sessions are better tolerated than one longer one.

Exercises to Avoid With Back Arthritis

Avoid heavy deadlifts, loaded spinal flexion (sit-ups, weighted toe-touches), high-impact running with severe OA and unsupported overhead pressing. Swap for partial squats, bird-dog, glute bridges and stationary cycling. For a personalised plan, find a back physiotherapist near you.

Back Arthritis Exercise FAQ — People Also Ask

What are the best exercises for an arthritic back?

The best routine combines deep-core strengthening (pelvic tilts, bird-dog, glute bridges), spinal mobility (cat-cow, knee-to-chest) and low-impact aerobic work (walking, cycling, swimming). Done 3–4 times per week, this can reduce back pain by 25–40%.

How often should I do back exercises for arthritis?

Strengthening 2–3 times per week, mobility daily (5–10 minutes), aerobic 3–5 times per week (30 minutes, can be split into 3 × 10 min).

Can exercise cure back arthritis?

No, but it is the most effective non-surgical treatment for spinal OA and can delay or avoid the need for spinal injections or surgery. Benefits stop if exercise stops.

What exercises should I avoid with back arthritis?

Avoid heavy deadlifts, loaded sit-ups, high-impact running with severe OA and unsupported overhead pressing. Stick to partial squats, bird-dog and stationary cycling.

Are there gentle back exercises for severe arthritis?

Yes — pelvic tilts, supported knee-to-chest, cat-cow, pool walking and stationary cycling on low resistance. Two short 10-minute daily sessions are usually better tolerated.

How long until back exercises reduce arthritis pain?

Reduced stiffness within 2–3 weeks, meaningful pain reduction at 6–8 weeks, full benefit at 12 weeks of consistent practice.

Related Back & Arthritis Guides

- Osteoarthritis exercises — full programme
 - Osteoarthritis treatment options (UK)
 - Rheumatoid arthritis exercises
 - More back exercises for osteoarthritis
 - Back exercises for rheumatoid arthritis
 - Anti-inflammatory diet for arthritis
 - Find a back physiotherapist near you
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Q&A

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General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk